LESSON 6 · 3RD TERM · COLOR FUNDAMENTALS

Color Temperature

Warm vs cool and how light changes color

Color temperature is one of the most powerful tools for creating convincing light in a painting or drawing. Light and shadow don't just differ in value — they differ in temperature. This is what makes them feel alive.

KEY CONCEPTS

Warm & Cool

Warm colors: reds, oranges, yellows. Cool colors: blues, blue-greens, blue-violets. Green and red-violet sit in the middle. These categories are relative — a warm blue and a cool blue both exist.

Light Temperature

Most natural light sources have a temperature: sunlight is warm (yellow-orange), shade/sky is cool (blue). Firelight is very warm; moonlight is very cool. Matching the temperature of your light source makes lighting feel real.

The Warm/Cool Rule

When the light is warm, the shadows are cool — and vice versa. This complementary relationship exists because the shadow is lit by the ambient sky light, which is opposite to the direct light source's temperature. This is the most important color temperature principle.

Atmospheric Perspective

As objects recede into the distance, they become cooler, more blue, and less saturated. This is atmospheric perspective — the effect of atmosphere on color. Foreground: warm and saturated. Background: cool and grey.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Paint the same scene twice: warm light / cool shadow, then cool light / warm shadow.
2. Go outside and observe the temperature difference between sunlit areas and shaded areas.
3. Paint a simple landscape and deliberately push the atmospheric perspective.

FURTHER READING

- **Proko – Color Temperature**
  https://youtu.be/AZhO4VjQUPE
- **Ctrl+Paint – Temperature**